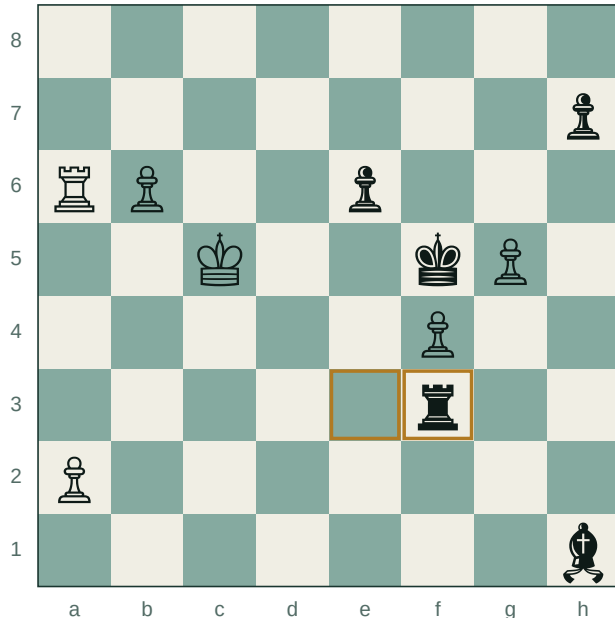


Advanced-pawn tactics: White, move 38

Advanced-pawn tactics

White to move



Previous move: 37...Rf3. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

38. b7 Rc3+ 39. Kd4 Bxb7 40. Ra5+ Kxf4 41. Kxc3

38.b7 The pawn moves from b6 to b7. Recorded reply: **38...Rc3+**.

39.Kd4 The king moves from c5 to d4. Recorded reply: **39...Bxb7**.

40.Ra5+ Check restricts Black to 6 legal replies here. Recorded reply: **40...Kxf4**.

41.Kxc3 The king captures the rook on c3.

At the end, nominal material is White 7 / Black 5 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +3. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +3: the balance goes from -1 to +2. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A far-advanced pawn may be weak if unsupported. Check whether the opponent can capture it with tempo or blockade it permanently.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A pawn near promotion forces the defender to respect urgent threats. Its strength can create forks, deflections, or mating ideas even when it never actually promotes.

HOW TO LOOK

Count the remaining pushes and identify the blocker. Look for forcing moves that remove or distract that blocker.

The defending king is on f5. Geometrically undefended: bishop on h1. Check for tactical protection.